pp. 133–134 (1977); H. Eckenrode, Separation of Church and State in Virginia 106–108 (1910).

In the Memorial and Remonstrance, Madison objected to the proposed assessment on the ground that it would coerce a form of religious devotion in violation of conscience. In Madison's view, government should not "'force a citizen to contribute three pence only of his property for the support of any one establishment.'" *Flast*, *supra*, at 103 (quoting 2 Writings of James Madison 183, 186 (G. Hunt ed. 1901)). This Madisonian prohibition does not depend on the amount of property conscripted for sectarian ends. Any such taking, even one amounting to "three pence only," violates conscience. 392 U. S., at 103; cf. *supra*, at 134–135. The proposed bill ultimately died in committee; and the General Assembly instead enacted legislation forbidding "compelled" support of religion. See A Bill for Establishing Religious Freedom, reprinted in 2 Papers of Thomas Jefferson 545–546 (J. Boyd ed. 1950); see also *Flast*, 392 U. S., at 104, n. 24. Madison himself went on to become, as *Flast* put it, "the leading architect of the religion clauses of the First Amendment." *Id.*, at 103. *Flast* was thus informed by "the specific evils" identified in the public arguments of "those who drafted the Establishment Clause and fought for its adoption." *Id.*, at 103–104; see also Feldman, Intellectual Origins of the Establishment Clause, 77 N. Y. U. L. Rev. 346, 351 (2002) ("[T]he Framers' generation worried that conscience would be violated if citizens were required to pay taxes to support religious institutions with whose beliefs they disagreed"); McConnell, Coercion: The Lost Element of Establishment, 27 Wm. & Mary L. Rev. 933, 936–939 (1986).

Respondents contend that these principles demonstrate their standing to challenge the STO tax credit. In their view the tax credit is, for *Flast* purposes, best understood as a governmental expenditure. That is incorrect.

It is easy to see that tax credits and governmental expenditures can have similar economic consequences, at least for